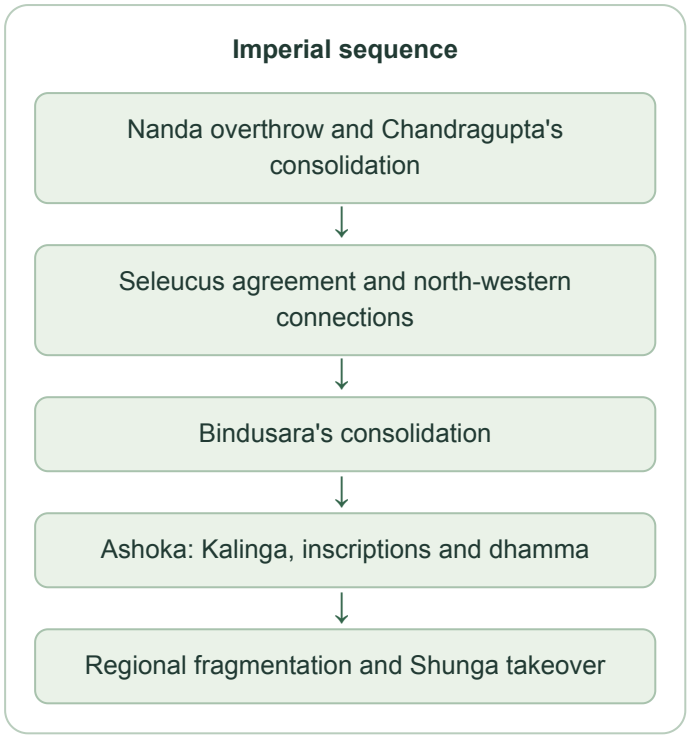
The Maurya Empire

1. Chronology and extent

Magadha → Pataliputra → first large subcontinental empire. Dates vary between reconstructions: the chapter uses **c.324–187 BCE**; common modern chronologies use approximately **322/321–185 BCE**. Do not mix accession and coronation dates as though all sources agree.

Ruler / stage	Essential facts
Chandragupta, c.321–297 BCE	Overthrew Nandas with **Chanakya/Kautilya**; consolidated Magadha and north-west. Greek **Sandrokottos/Sandrocottus** identified with him by **William Jones**
Seleucus settlement, c.305–303 BCE	Conflict followed by territorial/diplomatic agreement; areas associated with **Arachosia, Gedrosia and Paropamisadae** passed under Mauryan control; **500 elephants** given to Seleucus. Exact boundaries and marriage-alliance details debated
Bindusara, c.297–273 BCE	Greek **Amitrochates**, linked to **Amitraghata** (“slayer of foes”); extended/consolidated southern control, but precise conquests uncertain
Ashoka, c.268–232 BCE	Accession sometimes placed **c.273 BCE**, with later consecration; Buddhist accounts describe a succession struggle, not independently proved slaughter of 99 brothers
Kalinga, c.261 BCE	Conquered in **eighth regnal year after consecration**, recorded in **Major Rock Edict XIII**; remorse became central to royal dhamma policy
After c.232 BCE	Regional fragmentation and later rulers including **Dasharatha**; **Brihadratha**, last Maurya, killed by commander **Pushyamitra Shunga**, conventionally **c.185 BCE** (chapter: 187)

- Imperial centres connected the **north-west/Afghanistan, Gangetic basin, western India and much of the Deccan**. Far-southern **Cholas, Pandyas, Satiyaputras and Keralaputras** were neighbours, not all Mauryan provinces. **Sri Lanka/Tamraparni** was outside the empire.
- A map of maximum extent is a reconstruction; inscription distribution does not establish identical administrative control everywhere. Core Magadha, provincial centres, routes, forests and frontier areas differed.
- Jain tradition: Chandragupta renounced, accompanied **Bhadrabahu** south to **Shravanabelagola**, and practised **sallekhana**. Treat as later religious tradition, not a contemporary eyewitness record.
- Bindusara's association with **Ajivikas**, and Taranatha's account of conquest “between the seas”, are literary traditions. Greek sources mention **Deimachus**; Pliny records **Dionysius** sent by Ptolemy II, but the exact recipient/timing is less secure.



2. Sources: evidence and limits

Source	Use / caution
Ashokan inscriptions	Contemporary royal communications: policy, officials, ethics, places and external contacts. They present royal claims, not neutral accounts of every subject's life
Arthashastra	Sanskrit treatise attributed to **Kautilya/Chanakya/Vishnugupta**; statecraft, economy, taxation, diplomacy, security and law. **15 books**; earlier statecraft material with later compilation/redaction. Not a verbatim administrative manual demonstrably enforced across every Mauryan province
Megasthenes' Indica	Seleucus' envoy at Chandragupta's court; Pataliputra, society and administration. Original lost; fragments in **Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny**; eyewitness observation mixed with hearsay and Greek categories
Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription, c.150 CE	Retrospectively credits **Pushyagupta**, Chandragupta's governor, with Sudarshana lake; **Tushaspha** under Ashoka with related works. A later record about Mauryan activity
Buddhist texts	**Dipavamsa, Mahavamsa, Ashokavadana/Divyavadana**; Ashoka's sacred biography, missions, queens and conversion traditions
Jain / other literature	**Hemachandra—Parishishtaparvan**; **Vishakhadatta—Mudrarakshasa** (court intrigues); **Dandin—Dashakumaracharita; Bana—Kadambari**; later texts require chronological caution
Mamulanar / Sangam references	Mauryan southern campaigns and local powers; not proof of uniform imperial administration in the Tamil south
Archaeology	Pillars, caves, pottery, coins and **Kumrahar's 80-pillared hall** supplement texts

Arthashastra: *artha* = material/political well-being, not merely money. Discusses rulers' welfare duties alongside coercion, spies and practical power politics. **R. Shamasastry brought it to modern scholarly attention in 1905**; publication followed. “India's Machiavelli” is a comparison, not an ancient title.

Indica traps: its **seven occupational classes**—philosophers, cultivators, herders/hunters, artisans/traders, soldiers, overseers, councillors—are **not seven varnas**. Claims of no slavery, no famine or no writing conflict with other evidence. Descriptions of Krishna/Heracles and Shiva/Dionysus reflect Greek identifications.

3. Ashoka: personal faith and public dhamma

- Earlier service at **Ujjain and Taxila**, mother **Subhadrangi**, wife **Devi/Mahadevi**, and association with **Nigrodha or Samudra** belong principally to Buddhist narrative traditions.
- Other named queens: **Asandhimitra, Padmavati, Tissarakkha**; **Karuvaki** is named in the **Queen's Edict** as mother of **Tivara**. **Mahinda and Sanghamitta** are prominent in Sri Lankan mission traditions.
- Inscriptional titles: **Devanampiya** (“beloved of the gods”), **Piyadasi/Priyadarshi**; personal name **Ashoka appears at Maski**, with other named versions also known.
- Buddhism influenced Ashoka, but public **dhamma was a broad ethical and social programme**, not simply an order to convert everyone to Buddhism. Respect extended to **Brahmanas, shramanas and other sects**; Ajivika cave gifts demonstrate patronage beyond Buddhism.
- Duties: respect parents/elders/teachers; kindness to servants and enslaved people; generosity; truth, purity, restraint and compassion; avoid needless killing and sectarian abuse; promote welfare and responsible government.
- **Dhamma-vijaya** prioritised ethical persuasion over conquest. It did **not** mean dismantling the army, relinquishing Kalinga or abolishing punishment; Ashoka retained coercive authority towards forest peoples and the death penalty.



Interpretations: Buddhist-inspired kingship; a shared ethic among diverse subjects; paternal governance and imperial cohesion. These overlap. Avoid describing it as either entirely sectarian or modern secular democracy.

4. Inscriptions: language, script and geography

- **Prakrit** in **Brahmi** predominates; **Kharoshthi** at **Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra**, read **right to left**. Brahmi generally reads left to right.

- **Greek and Aramaic** occur in north-western/Afghan records, including **Kandahar**. Sanskrit and Pali are not the standard language of the major Ashokan corpus.
- **James Prinsep, 1837:** key decipherment of Brahmi/Ashokan inscriptions; do not repeat the chapter's **1887** error.
- Learn categories rather than a supposedly fixed total of monuments: **14 Major Rock Edicts**, Minor Rock Edicts, **2 Separate Kalinga Edicts**, **7 Major Pillar Edicts**, minor pillar/Schism/Queen's records and cave dedications. Surviving versions vary by place.

Major Rock Edicts I–XIV

Edict	Quick recall
I	Restrictions on animal sacrifice/slaughter and some festivities; reduction of royal-kitchen killing
II	Human/animal medical care, medicinal plants, wells/trees; southern neighbours and Antiochus
III	**Yuktas, rajukas, pradesikas** to tour every **five years**; moral instruction and administrative business
IV	**Bheri-ghosha** → **dhamma-ghosha**; improved conduct and restraint
V	**Dhamma-mahamatras**, appointed **13 years after consecration**; welfare across communities, including prisoners
VI	King accessible to reports at all times; council/officials and urgent business
VII	Coexistence and self-restraint among sects
VIII	**Dhamma-yatras** replace pleasure tours; visit to **Sambodhi/Bodh Gaya**, ten years after consecration
IX	Critique of empty ceremonies; ethical conduct more fruitful
X	Fame/glory valued only insofar as it advances dhamma
XI	Gift of dhamma; duties towards parents, friends, servants and religious persons
XII	**Religious concord and restraint in speech**; do not praise one's sect by disparaging others
XIII	**Kalinga war**, suffering/remorse and **dhamma-vijaya**; Hellenistic rulers and southern neighbours
XIV	Explains varied lengths, repetition, local suitability and possible omissions/errors in edicts

XIII's foreign rulers: Antiochus II—Syria; Ptolemy II—Egypt; Antigonus—Macedonia; Magas—Cyrene; Alexander—usually identified with Epirus, identification debated. These are claimed ethical/diplomatic horizons, not conquered provinces.

Major Pillar Edicts I–VII

Edict	Quick recall
I	Governance and protection through dhamma; earnestness/self-examination
II	Little evil, much good; compassion, generosity, truth and purity
III	Self-examination; recognise anger, pride, envy and cruelty
IV	**Rajukas' judicial authority**, fairness and **three-day respite for condemned prisoners**
V	Animal protection, limits on killing and specified practices; prisoner releases
VI	Welfare, respect for sects and royal personal engagement
VII	Summary of dhamma measures, officials, persuasion and welfare; preserved on **Delhi–Topra** pillar

Place–record pairs

Place / record	Remember
Dhauli and Jaugada—Odisha	Separate Kalinga Edicts; fair administration and paternal concern; **"All men are my children."** Major edicts XI–XIII omitted in these versions, separate texts supplied
Erragudi/Yerragudi—Andhra Pradesh	Major Rock Edicts; not Karnataka
Kalsi—Uttarakhand; Girnar—Gujarat	Major Rock Edict sites
Sannati—Karnataka	Fragments of **XII and XIV**, with separate edicts; **not a complete set of all fourteen**
Maski—Karnataka	Personal name **Ashoka**
Bhabru/Bairat—Rajasthan	Explicit faith in Buddha, dhamma and Sangha; recommends **seven** textual passages, not six
Rummindei/Lumbini—Nepal	Buddha's birthplace; visit **20 years after consecration**; **bali exemption**, produce share reduced to **one-eighth**, not one-eighth of the previous tax
Nigali Sagar—Nepal	Enlarged stupa of **Konakamana Buddha** in **14th year**; visited in **20th year**
Brahmagiri—Karnataka	Minor Rock Edicts; administrative communication and **Suvarnagiri/Isila**
Prayagraj/Allahabad pillar	Major pillar texts, **Queen's Edict** and **Schism Edict** are distinct records. Later **Samudragupta** and **Jahangir** inscriptions share the monument
Sanchi, Sarnath, Kaushambi traditions	Schism instructions: preserve Sangha unity
Sohgaura copper plate / Mahasthan	Early relief/granary measures; precise dating/royal attribution debated. Not securely signed personal edicts of Chandragupta

Minor Rock Edict I: Ashoka had been a lay follower for over **2½ years** before greater zeal; this is **not 2½ years after accession**. Conversion was a process; sources disagree on the precise teacher and timing.

5. Statecraft: seven limbs and governing machinery

Saptanga: Swamin—king; Amatya—officials; Janapada—territory/people; Durga—fort; Kosha—treasury; Danda/Bala—coercive/military power; Mitra—ally. These are interdependent elements, not seven separate ministries.

Institution / officer	Function
King	Supreme political/judicial authority; welfare duty, accessibility, security and royal orders; Ashoka's paternal ideal differs from claims of divine descent
Mantris / mantriparishad	Advisers and council; smaller inner consultations alongside wider council. Do not assume every Greek and Sanskrit administrative term describes precisely the same body
Tirthas	High functionaries; familiar list of **18** includes chief minister, purohita, yuvaraja, senapati
Amatyas / mahamatras	High officials with varied executive, judicial and special responsibilities
Adhyakshas	Departmental superintendents, especially economic functions; not synonymous with village headmen
Samaharta	Revenue assessment/collection and related administration
Sannidhata	Treasury, stores and custody; distinguish collection from custody
Akshapatala	Accounts/records/audit establishment
Dauvarika	Palace/door administration
Dhamma-mahamatras / anta-mahamatras	Ethical/welfare duties / frontier responsibilities
Pulisani, pativedakas	Royal agents/reporters; keep ruler informed

- Textual salary scales show hierarchy: **48,000 panas** for top officers; **12,000** for council members in cited lists; not a complete surviving Mauryan payroll.
- Appointment tests in Arthashastra: **dharma, money, desire and fear**—assessment of loyalty/integrity. Security included **stationary (samstha) and mobile (sanchara) spies**, palace precautions and female guards.

Provinces and local administration

Five major centres: Pataliputra—imperial core; Taxila—north-west; Ujjain—west; Tosali—Kalinga/east; Suvarnagiri—south. **Tosali and Kalinga are not two additional separate eastern provinces** in this standard reconstruction.



- Functions overlapped; inscriptional and Arthashastra schemes cannot be mechanically combined into a perfectly uniform nationwide hierarchy.
- Arthashastra settlement units: **sthaniya—800 villages; dronamukha—400; kharvatika—200; samgrahana—10**. **Dronamukha is one word**, not separate “drona” and “mukha” units.
- **Nagaraka:** city administration; **gramika/gramani:** village head; **gramavriddhas:** elders; **gopas/sthanikas:** records and revenue duties.
- Megasthenes' **Pataliputra municipal board: 30 members, six groups of five—industry; foreigners; births/deaths; trade/weights/measures; manufactured goods; sales-tax collection**. Care of foreigners included medical assistance, burial and estate return. Reported sales levy **one-tenth**; do not confuse with agricultural **one-sixth**.

6. Army, law and diplomacy

Military system

- Large standing forces and forts, backed by revenue, supplies, trained commanders and reserve/auxiliary forces. Greek army totals are **literary estimates**, not audited numbers.
- Six military committees of five in Megasthenes: **navy; transport/supplies; infantry; cavalry; chariots; elephants**—distinct from six municipal committees.
- **Senapati**, **nayakas** and specialised officers: **patti/padati—infantry; ashva—horses; ratha—chariots; hasti—elephants**. **Maula:** hereditary troops; **bhritaka:** hired soldiers; forest/allied contingents also used.
- **Durga** includes fortified centres and siege preparedness; **danda/bala** is the armed/coercive limb. The chapter discusses the army under both—avoid swapping the definitions.

Justice

- King supreme; **dharmasthas** associated with civil adjudication; **pradeshtas** with criminal/order functions; local adjudication also involved elders.
- Four legal bases: **dharma—normative/sacred law; vyavahara—legal procedure/evidence; charitra—custom; rajashasana—royal command**. The source's extra “royal proclamations” under dharma is misplaced.

- Fines, forfeiture, corporal and capital penalties; status-based inequalities coexisted with Ashoka's stated pursuit of fair procedure. **Pillar IV's three-day respite does not abolish execution**.
- **Bandhanagara:** prison; local detention/police establishments also existed. Ashoka urged officials to avoid unjust imprisonment and harsh treatment.

Diplomacy: shadgunya

Policy	Meaning
Sandhi	Peace/agreement, often when weaker
Vigraha	Hostility/war when favourable
Asana	Strategic waiting/neutrality
Yana	March/preparation for expedition
Samshraya	Seek protection/shelter
Dvaidhibhava	Peace with one power while opposing another

Vijigishu = ruler seeking conquest. Policy depends on relative strength and circumstances; these are strategic choices, not fixed moral rules. Envoys: **nisrishtartha—full powers; parimitartha—limited mandate; shasanahara—message bearer**.

7. Economy, taxes and occupational organisation

Agriculture and revenue

- Agriculture mainstay: **rice, wheat, barley, millets, pulses, oilseeds, sugarcane**; irrigation and new settlements expanded production. **Kshetra/kshetrika:** field/landholder; **upavasa:** tenant in the cited terminology.
- State domains and private holdings coexisted; **sitadhyaksha** supervised crown agriculture. Settling cultivators on uncultivated land enlarged the revenue base; sharecroppers and dependent labour worked state/private lands.

Term	Recall
Bhaga	King's share of produce, commonly **one-sixth**; not universal for every crop/land/period
Bali	Additional tribute/levy; do **not** substitute it for bhaga or assign every levy the same rate
Pindakara	Collective assessment on groups of villages
Hiranya	Cash payment/levy
Kara	Tax/tribute; nature varied
Udakabhaga	Irrigation charge; textual rates vary with source/method, often **one-fifth to one-third**
Pranaya	Extraordinary/emergency contribution
Shulka	Customs/tolls on goods

Term	Recall
Vishti	Compulsory labour obligation

Taxes paid in cash and kind, not cash alone. Army/officials, roads, forts, irrigation and welfare consumed revenue. Grain reserves and relief records matter; no credible inference that famine never occurred.

Crafts, commerce and regulation

- Textiles: **Varanasi, Mathura, Bengal, Gandhara, Ujjain**. State enterprises and private activity coexisted; mines, metals, forests, pastures and trade regulated.
- Officers: **sutradhyaksha—textiles; akaradhyaksha—mines; lohadhyaksha—metals/iron; panyadhyaksha—trade/pricing; samsthadhyaksha—markets; rupadarshaka—coin inspection; pautavadhyaksha—weights/measures; vivitadhyaksha—pastures; sunadhyaksha—slaughterhouses**.
- **Pataliputra—internal routes; Taxila—north-west/Central Asia; Tamralipti—eastern port; Bharukachchha/Broach—western port**. Land, river and maritime exchange linked regions and external markets.
- **Shrenis/pugas:** occupational/corporate associations; **jyeshthaka** a headman. Production, quality, collective interests and exchange important; do not import every later guild-banking function uncritically into this period.
- **Punch-marked silver coins** facilitated exchange; moneylending and interest attested. Iron use expanded but **predated the Mauryas**; they did not invent iron technology. Labour included **karmakaras** (wage workers), enslaved people and pledged/dependent workers.

8. Society and slavery

- Varna hierarchy persisted alongside occupational change and urban groups. **Shudras** participated in cultivation/crafts; **Chandalas and Shvapakas**, described as marginal/excluded groups, reveal inequality. Ashoka's edicts do not provide a full census of caste or social practice.
- **Dasas** and **bhatakas/bhritakas** appear in ethical instructions. Megasthenes' “no slaves” claim cannot establish absence of unfree labour; institutions differed from Greek slavery.
- Arthashastra differentiates forms of dependence, protection, redemption/manumission and restrictions. A woman enslaved to a master who fathers her child and the child's status are important PYQ themes.
- **2022 PYQ:** retain supplied key **(b), statements 2 and 3**; statement 1 on judicial punishment has generated interpretive disagreement. Do not generalise this exam key into a claim that every historical form of penal servitude was absent.

9. Art and material culture

Form / place	Features / traps
Ashokan pillars	Free-standing, tapering, smooth polished sandstone shafts, generally **monolithic**; separate capital/abacus components. Often Chunar sandstone. Not structural roof-support columns
Capital anatomy	Shaft → inverted-lotus/bell form → abacus → animal figure(s). **Sarnath four lions** inspired State Emblem; **Rampurva bull** another major example
Animal symbolism	**Lion:** sovereignty/Buddha as Shakyasimha; **bull:** strength/fertility; **elephant:** power and Buddha-birth tradition; **horse:** renunciation/departure; **wheel:** dharma/sovereignty; **lotus:** purity/fecundity. Meanings vary by context

Form / place	Features / traps
Pillar sites	Sarnath, Rampurva, Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, Rummindei, Nigali Sagar; Delhi–Topra/Meerut pillars moved in medieval times
Kumrahar, Patna	80-pillared hall; Pataliputra combined timber, brick and stone, not complete replacement of wood everywhere
Barabar / Nagarjuni	Rock-cut caves with polished interiors; **Sudama, Lomas Rishi**; forms imitate timber construction. Ajivika dedications by **Ashoka and Dasharatha**; caves themselves are **stone**, not wooden
Dhauli	Rock-cut **elephant**, not a “Dhauli cave complex”
Sanchi / Bodh Gaya	Ashokan brick nucleus of Great Stupa; later enlargement/gateways. **Vajrasana** linked to Ashoka. **84,000 stupas** is a sacred traditional number, not a verified construction count
Didarganj Yakshi / Lohanipur torso	Polished sculpture associated with early historic art; exact dating of Didarganj disputed, so avoid treating it as securely Ashokan solely because polished
Kanaganahalli near Sannati	**Ranyo Ashoka** labelled relief; **later commemorative representation**, not a proven portrait carved during Ashoka's lifetime
Other materials	Terracotta figurines, ring/disc stones, **NBPW**, punch-marked coins, iron implements, brick/timber and ring wells; distribution shows networks, not automatic political control

Achaemenid connections: royal inscriptions, polish, bell/lotus forms and animal capitals invite comparison. **Persian columns** often fluted, based and part of buildings; **Ashokan pillars** usually smooth, free-standing and monolithic in the shaft. Connections coexist with distinctive Indian forms; not simple copying.

Learning centres included **Taxila, Varanasi and Ujjain**; “university” is a modern shorthand, not proof of a modern institution. **Kalpasutra** is traditionally associated with Bhadrabahu; surviving compilation/transmission is later and layered.

10. Decline: use several explanations

- **Succession and overextension:** loss of strong central authority after Ashoka; provincial autonomy, distance and regional diversity made cohesion difficult.
- **Provincial oppression:** Taxila narratives and Kalinga instructions point to tensions over officials; evidence of concern, not a direct measurement of rebellion everywhere.
- **Fiscal strain:** large army, bureaucracy and expansion costs; **D.D. Kosambi** stressed economic pressure. Plausible interpretation, not a surviving imperial balance sheet.
- **Regional resource bases:** agricultural/iron/craft expansion helped new powers consolidate beyond Magadha; not a sudden single transfer of technology.
- **North-western pressures:** Hellenistic/Bactrian developments and later invasions interacted with declining control. Do not repeat the claim that the Greeks first entered India in **206 BCE**: Alexander came earlier; Antiochus III's **206 BCE** expedition is a distinct event, while Bactrian independence preceded it.
- **“Brahmanical reaction” / “pacifism weakened army”:** debated older explanations, associated with writers including **Haraprasad Shastri**. Respect for Brahmanas, non-Buddhist gifts and continued coercive institutions weaken a simple anti-Brahmana/disarmed-empire thesis.
- The absence of a Great Wall does not explain Mauryan collapse. China's wall-building, Scythian movement and South Asian invasions cannot be compressed into one direct cause.

11. PYQ revision and mains plans

Prelims recall

Year / theme	Answer / reason
2022: Arthashastra and slavery	**(b), 2 and 3** in supplied key; interpretive caution above
2022: edict–state matching	**(b), two pairs**: Dhauli–Odisha, Erragudi–Andhra correct; **Jaugada–Odisha, Kalsi–Uttarakhand**
2020: tolerance quotation	**(a) Ashoka**, **Major Rock Edict XII**
2019: Ranyo Ashoka portrait	**(a) Kanaganahalli/Kanganahalli**
2016: decipherer	**(b) James Prinsep**
2015: earliest monument listed	**(b) Dhauli elephant**; other listed temple/sculpture complexes are later
2002: Mudrarakshasa	**(d) Court intrigues at Chandragupta's time**, not gods versus demons
1998: southern/Sangam kingdoms	**(c) Major Rock Edicts II and XIII**
1998: food-grain relief record	**(a) Sohgaura copper plate**
1998: personal name	**(d) Maski**
1997: right-to-left script / incorrect pillar statement	**(d) Kharoshthi / (d) parts of architectural structures**
1995: inscriptional name	**(d) Piyadassi**

2022 GS I: lion and bull figures

Question: Discuss the significance of the lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture.

Plan: distinguish religious meanings from political authority → lion/Buddha and Sarnath, bull/fertility and Rampurva → wider examples such as Nandi/Shiva and lion imagery in temples → explain continuity, patronage and changing contexts. Do not restrict an all-India question to Mauryan monuments.

2015 History Optional: West Asian and Mediterranean contacts

Question: Delineate the nature and impact of India's contact with western Asia and the Mediterranean world during the Mauryan period.

Plan: Seleucus agreement/envoys → trade and routes → Greek/Aramaic inscriptions and Hellenistic rulers → artistic comparison and selective adaptation → limits: diplomatic/ethical claims are not evidence of military rule over Mediterranean kingdoms.

2014 History Optional: dhamma and military strength

Question: Discuss different interpretations of historians about the nature of Ashoka's “dhamma”. Did his principle of “dhamma-vijaya” render the Mauryan empire militaristically weak?

Plan: Buddhist inspiration, public ethic, welfare/cohesion → Kalinga and restrained conquest → retained army, punishment and forest warning → multicausal decline after Ashoka. A correlation with later decline does not establish pacifism as its cause.

2012 History Optional: adhyakshas

Question: Examine the role of adhyaksha in the Mauryan administration.

Plan: define superintendent → agriculture/mining/textiles/trade/weights/military examples → revenue, quality and state enterprises → distinguish normative Arthashastra from evidence of uniform actual practice.

2010 History Optional: guilds and trade organisations

Question: Assess the role of guilds and trade organisations in the development of early Indian economy.

Plan: production, skilled labour, quality, collective organisation and trade networks → regulation and taxation → trace later developments where relevant. The question is wider than the Mauryan period.

References for disputed details

- Supplied chapter; Archaeological Survey of India: Sannati inscription texts and epigraphical survey.
- Ashokan edicts: translated texts; Asiatic Society: Prinsep's work.
- Metropolitan Museum: Mauryan chronology and art.